

Player to watch **RACHIN RAVINDRA**

New Zealand will hope Rachin Ravindra can emulate his performances from the 2023 ODI World Cup in India, where he amassed 578 runs in 10 innings, including three centuries.

Rachin was in form throughout 2023, averaging 41 in the 25 matches he played that year.

This ICC Champions Trophy presents an opportunity for him to improve his record in Pakistan. In four ODIs in the country, Rachin has managed just 62 runs — a tally well below his calibre.



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former showed his pyrotechnics in the tri-nation series, scoring an unbeaten 106 off just 74 deliveries against Pakistan, while Bracewell chipped in with a 23-ball 31. Kane Williamson, Daryl Mitchell, and Tom Latham, who are expected to bat at numbers three, four, and five, respectively, can play the perfect foil to the two hitters by setting up platforms. However, to maximise the batter-friendly wickets in Pakistan, where New Zealand plays Bangladesh and the host, Latham could make way for Mark Chapman, who boasts a strike rate of 105.14.

But the biggest change for New Zealand has come right at the top, where Will Young has been preferred over Devon Conway as Rachin Ravindra's opening partner. Conway impressed during the 2023 ODI World Cup, amassing 372 runs in 10 innings. However, the southpaw suffered an injury in 2024 and played his first 50-over match since the World Cup semifinal during the tri-nation series.

New Zealand will have to choose between Conway and Young, given the need to improve its PowerPlay (1-10) run rate, which stands at 5.36 in 2025. While most boxes are ticked in the batting department, New Zealand will be desperate to settle on a bowling combination.

For the first time since 2010, the Kiwi pace battery will enter an ICC competition without Tim Southee and Trent Boult. Its lead pacers — Lockie Ferguson and Matt Henry — have considerable experience, but an injury scare for the former on the cusp of the tournament may leave the unit shorthanded.

The backups — Ben Sears, Nathan Smith, and Will O'Rourke — have only 15 ODI appearances between them and remain untested in ICC events.

As a result, New Zealand will relish playing two of its group-stage matches in Karachi (against Bangladesh) and Dubai (against India), venues that favour spinners. Even though Santner is the only

full-time spinner in the squad, the Kiwis boast a plethora of all-rounders who can contribute with the ball.

Since 2006, the 2013 and 2017 Champions Trophy editions are the only 50-over ICC tournaments where New Zealand missed the semifinals. The two favourable venues might just provide the stroke of fortune the Kiwis need to clear this hurdle.

SQUAD

Mitchell Santner (c), Devon Conway (wk), Tom Latham (wk), Kane Williamson, Will Young, Michael Bracewell, Mark Chapman, Rachin Ravindra, Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Nathan Smith, Lockie Ferguson, Matt Henry, Will O'Rourke, Ben Sears